PowerTies Consulting Group

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The Free Marketing Path

The 12 steps PowerTies runs to market a real business for $0 — every tool named, every step checkable, nothing held back.

A guide + checklist from PowerTies Consulting Group
powerties.us · Free to use, free to share

> **HOW WE WORK — THE VALUES BEHIND EVERYTHING WE PUBLISH**
>
> **HONOR.** We say what's true — including about ourselves. If a number in here is zero, we print zero.
>
> **SOVEREIGNTY.** Your business, your data, your call. Everything here runs on tools you own and control.
>
> **GRATITUDE.** Strengths first. You've already built something real; this builds on it, not over it.
>
> **SERVICE.** The test of every step: who does it help, and how will they feel it?

What this is

This is the exact system a one-person consulting business in Queens, NY runs to market itself. Every step is $0 or near-$0, every tool named is the real tool, and every step ends with a checklist — 62 items in all. Work it in order the first time through; after that, revisit whichever step your numbers say is weakest.

One note before the steps: a path like this produces work in every direction — research, publishing, follow-up, measurement. Somebody has to coordinate it. PowerTies assigns that ring-leader role to an AI agent, with the owner approving every outward action. You can wear the hat yourself for $0; the cost is time, and naming that trade honestly is the point of this guide.

THE HONEST NUMBERS — OUR BASELINE, OCTOBER 2026

We publish our funnel monthly, good or bad. At our starting line (October 13, 2026): **79 outreach emails sent · 55 delivered · 0 replies · $0 revenue.** A system can be busy and still produce nothing — activity is not proof; the funnel is. The one failure we'd already found and fixed was ours: early emails went to guessed addresses and bounced. Verified addresses only, from then on. Our all-in stack costs under $60 a month; the path itself is runnable at $0, and every paid line has a free route.

Step 1 — Website: your home base

A fast, credible home base on the internet that you own and control. Everything else — search, social, referrals, outreach — points back to one place. If that place is a rented social profile, you don't own your front door.

- ☐ Pick free hosting (Cloudflare Pages or GitHub Pages) and create the site
- ☐ Build the core pages: home, about, your offer, contact
- ☐ Add a lead-capture form so visitors can raise their hand
- ☐ Connect your own domain (optional, roughly $10–15/yr, but it looks established)
- ☐ Check the site on your phone — most of your visitors will be on theirs

How PowerTies does it: powerties.us is a plain static HTML site on Cloudflare Pages, wired to a GitHub repo — every push redeploys automatically. No page builder, no monthly hosting bill.

Step 2 — Get found: Google Business Profile & Search Console

Most local buying starts with a search. Your Business Profile is the free listing that puts you on the map; Search Console is how you tell Google your site exists and see what people searched to find you.

- ☐ Claim or create your Google Business Profile and complete every field — hours, services, photos
- ☐ Verify your site in Google Search Console
- ☐ Submit your sitemap in Search Console
- ☐ Write plain page titles and descriptions that say what you do and where
- ☐ Keep your business name, address, and phone identical everywhere — consistency matters

How PowerTies does it: We verified Search Console, submitted our sitemap, and removed a duplicate Business Profile — the surviving profile carries 8 reviews at 5.0 stars. Google asked us for a video re-verification; that's normal. Budget the 20 minutes.

Step 3 — AI-search visibility

Buyers increasingly ask an AI — ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity — instead of scrolling search results. AI answers are built from pages that state facts plainly. Clear Q&A; content plus structured data is what gets cited.

- ☐ Write 10–15 questions your buyers actually ask, in the words they use
- ☐ Answer each one plainly in 2–4 sentences with real facts — areas served, who it's for
- ☐ Add FAQPage JSON-LD schema that matches the visible Q&As;
- ☐ State one consistent public location (we say Queens, NY — no street address needed)
- ☐ Keep the same facts — name, services — identical on every profile

How PowerTies does it: Our homepage carries a 14-question FAQ written the way people actually ask AI, with matching FAQPage schema — live and verified.

Step 4 — Content system

Buyers check you out before they call. A steady drip of genuinely helpful posts builds the familiarity that makes you the obvious call — and every post is another page search engines and AI tools can find.

- ☐ Pick 3–5 pillar topics you can teach from real experience
- ☐ Set a weekly rhythm you can sustain (ours: two posts a week)
- ☐ Draft a week of posts in one sitting and queue them in Buffer or Metricool (free tiers)
- ☐ Repurpose every idea: post → short video → email → FAQ answer
- ☐ Every couple of weeks, check what performed and lean the next posts toward the winners

How PowerTies does it: A Sunday automation drafts our Monday and Wednesday posts from the content calendar, checks the last two weeks of performance first so the winners set the treatment, and queues them in Buffer.

Step 5 — Lead magnet + quiz funnel

Most visitors aren't ready to buy, but many will trade an email address for a genuinely useful diagnostic. A short quiz holds the qualifying conversation for you, 24/7 — and its result prescribes the next step.

- ☐ Design a short quiz or diagnostic that surfaces the customer's real problem
- ☐ Make the result genuinely useful on its own — a snapshot, not a teaser
- ☐ Let the result prescribe one next step — your paid offer
- ☐ Route every completion into your CRM as a lead
- ☐ Link the quiz from your homepage, your posts, and your profiles

How PowerTies does it: Our free diagnostic is MLOT — Money Left on the Table. Two short quizzes feed it, and the offer lands because the visitor just saw their own gaps, in their own numbers.

Step 6 — Booking + payment

Every manual step between "I'm interested" and a paid, booked call leaks buyers. A booking link plus a payment link removes the friction entirely.

- ☐ Create a booking page for your intro or paid session, with a few smart intake questions
- ☐ Create a payment link for your entry offer (Square: no monthly fee, processing per sale)
- ☐ Wire the flow together — pay → book → CRM — pick one order and test it
- ☐ Put the booking link on your site, your quiz results, and your email signature
- ☐ Run one end-to-end test booking from your phone before sharing the link anywhere

How PowerTies does it: Our stack research found Cal.com's free tier stronger than the big-name schedulers' — but the pattern is the point, not the tool: pay → book → CRM, with no email tennis.

Step 7 — CRM + automation

Leads die in inboxes. A CRM remembers what you won't, and automation handles the filing, summarizing, and reminding. The rule that keeps it safe: AI can draft; a human approves every outward send.

- ☐ Set up a CRM (Zoho's free tier is enough) with Leads and Contacts
- ☐ Connect your lead sources: website form and quiz completions become CRM leads automatically
- ☐ Add an approval flow: replies get drafted responses; a human approves before anything sends
- ☐ Add a daily lead summary so a new lead never sits unseen
- ☐ Write down your one inviolable rule: no automated outward sends without human approval

How PowerTies does it: Self-hosted n8n runs our email triage, CRM lead creation, morning digest, and payment handling. PowerTies pays about $15/mo for a small server so it runs around the clock; running it on your own computer costs $0.

Step 8 — Reviews + directories

Reviews are the proof strangers trust most, and directory listings are free shelf space. Most small businesses simply never ask. Asking — systematically, every time — is the whole trick.

- ☐ Get your Google review short link from your Business Profile
- ☐ Build a short post-job review request and send it after every finished job

- ☐ Claim your free listings: Bing Places, Apple Maps, Yelp, BBB
- ☐ Claim a Nextdoor Business Page and post one useful tip a week
- ☐ Respond to every review — yes, the awkward ones too — briefly and graciously

How PowerTies does it: Our Google profile carries 8 reviews at 5.0 stars and our Clutch profile is published. Both were built the same unglamorous way: do the work, then ask — with a direct link — every time.

Step 9 — Community

Buyers trust people they've watched be useful. Communities are also free market research: you hear the exact words customers use for their problems — the same words your FAQ and posts should use.

- ☐ Join 3–5 communities where your buyers ask questions — trade subs, local groups, Discords
- ☐ Spend your first two weeks answering questions genuinely: no links, no pitch
- ☐ Set up F5Bot keyword alerts (free) for your trade and town so you never miss a thread
- ☐ Disclose who you are when you share your own process or results
- ☐ Keep a notes file of the best questions you see — they become your posts and FAQs

How PowerTies does it: We run a two-week listening phase before posting anything of our own: answer first, self-mention last, and log every pain in the customer's own words.

Step 10 — Partnerships & barter

Cash is the scarcest thing a small business has; skill and audience are not. A complementary business already talks to your next customers, and barter lets you buy what you need with what you already have: your expertise.

- ☐ Map 10 complementary, non-competing businesses that serve the same customers
- ☐ Draft a one-page agreement: scope, value each side gives, timeline, what happens if one side stalls
- ☐ Pitch 3 partners this week — and lead with what their customers get out of it
- ☐ Put every arrangement in writing, even between friends — especially between friends
- ☐ Track who sent you work and who you sent work to; visible reciprocity stays healthy

How PowerTies does it: Straight talk: barter income is taxable in the US at fair-market value (exchanges report it on Form 1099-B). Price both sides at your normal rates. Win-win-win or don't: good for your partner, good for their customer, good for you.

Step 11 — Outreach + measurement

Most outreach fails quietly because nobody measures it. A scored list, verified emails, small daily batches, and a weekly grading loop turn guessing into a system you can actually improve.

- ☐ Pick your territory from Census data first, then list named decision-makers at businesses that fit
- ☐ Score each lead's fit before anyone gets emailed — best first
- ☐ Verify every email address before sending; never guess an address pattern — guessed addresses bounce, and bounces destroy your deliverability
- ☐ Send small daily batches (we do about 10 a day, weekdays only) and log every send
- ☐ Track the funnel honestly: sent → delivered → replied → paid → revenue
- ☐ Grade weekly, per source: which sources produced replies — and which produced bounces?
- ☐ Set a 30-day checkpoint in advance: if replies are zero, diagnose the real cause instead of just sending more

How PowerTies does it: Our discovery legs pool into one queue: web research, a Google Maps scraper, community listening, and an AI research leg. Early lesson, learned the expensive way: removing guessed addresses was the single biggest deliverability fix we ever made.

Step 12 — Find your niche and research the solution

Steps 1–11 build the machine; this step aims it. You learn a niche's real pains — in their own words — by listening where they complain, ask, and compare notes. Participation converts research into relationships.

- ☐ Pick one niche candidate: a specific who with a specific, expensive problem
- ☐ Spend two weeks listening in 3–5 forums where they talk, before posting anything
- ☐ Keep a pains log — their exact words for their problems, not your paraphrase
- ☐ Use AI to cluster the pains and draft the solution angle they point to
- ☐ Participate genuinely — answer, share your process — and note what resonates
- ☐ Test ONE niche-specific lead magnet or offer, and feed results back into Steps 4 and 11

How PowerTies does it: Some say pick the niche first. In our sequence the system came first and the niche sharpened through doing — research lands better when you already have something real to offer.

YOUR ONE NEXT STEP

See where your business is leaking money

The Path works as a system, but most owners find their biggest leak is in one place: the follow-up that never happened, the quote that went out and died, the manual work eating the week. Our free two-minute mini-assessment — the mini-MLOT — spots which kind of leak is costing you most, and what to fix first.

Take the mini-MLOT: powerties.us/quiz-mini-mlot.html

KEEP WALKING IT WITH US

The Free Marketing Path is a living, open project. The full interactive checklist (all 62 items, progress saved in your browser) and our published monthly numbers live at github.com/powertiesbiz-ai/free-marketing-path.

One practical idea a week: The Steward's Brief, our free newsletter — powerties-newsletter.beehiiv.com/subscribe. And owners walking the Path compare notes in our Discord: discord.gg/s3KcMgCaQU.

Best,
Keith
PowerTies Consulting Group